SkillBoost AI

AI Co-Founder · Business Strategy Report

YC Advisor · Growth Strategist · Investment Scorecard

India Market · June 2025 · Seed Stage

71	78	66	63	59
Biz Viability	Revenue Potential	GTM Strength	Competitive Str.	Investor Ready

■ **VERDICT: VALIDATE — Strong problem, weak distribution proof. Fix GTM before raising.**

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■ 01 Startup Snapshot — 10 Key Facts

Area	Detail
Startup	SkillBoost AI — AI-powered career guidance platform for Indian engineering students
Problem	Tier 2/3 B.Tech/BCA/BSc CS students lack personalised, affordable career coaching; <20% land degree-relevant jobs
Customer	~5M Tier 2/3 college students · Android users · Rs 3L–10L family income · Placement-anxious, 6–12 months from graduation
Value Prop	AI roadmap + skill-gap quiz + progress tracking — the personalised career co-pilot no EdTech player offers at India pricing
Pricing	Free (7-day) → Rs 99 Starter → Rs 299 Pro → Rs 1,999/yr Annual → Rs 499 Premium; blended ARPU ~Rs 200/month
Revenue Model	Freemium SaaS subscription; future upsells: mock interview, placement readiness, B2B college licences
SAM	$4.2B India online career & skill-dev market; SOM $42M (Tier 2/3 reachable in 3 years)
GTM	Organic: Instagram Reels, college WhatsApp groups, referral programme; Paid: retargeting motivated coders
Stage	Early prototype · Positive qualitative feedback · Pre-revenue · Solo technical founder
Risks	Solo founder execution risk · Low student WTP · Unproven D30 retention · EdTech giants could copy feature set

■ 02 Business Reality Check

Who pays?

• Final-year B.Tech/BCA/BSc CS students (Yr 3–4) facing imminent placement season. Parents co-pay when ROI is clear. Average budget Rs 200–400/month. Motivated by fear of unemployment, not aspiration.

Why do they pay?

• The product saves them from decision paralysis. Current alternatives (YouTube, seniors, placement cells) are unstructured and unaccountable. Students pay for clarity, structure, and a progress signal — not just content.

How will they discover the product?

• Instagram Reels (primary); college WhatsApp groups (highest conversion, lowest CAC); friend referrals; YouTube creator partnerships; retargeting users who watched coding motivation content.

Biggest growth risks?

• CAC creep: organic WhatsApp reach is finite per college; scaling means paid ads where student CPAs can exceed LTV.

• Seasonal demand: 70%+ of conversions likely cluster in 2 x 3-month placement seasons per year — cash flow will be lumpy.

• Retention cliff: if students land jobs or give up, churn spikes and word-of-mouth reverses.

Biggest monetisation risks?

• India's student segment has Rs 99 as a psychological ceiling for 'try it' and Rs 299 as a serious commitment — the gap is real.

• Free YouTube / ChatGPT can replicate the product perception (not the experience) for Rs 0.

• Low-income users may adopt, love the product, but never convert — inflating DAU while revenue stagnates.

Weak assumptions to validate NOW

• D30 retention > 25% — no evidence yet; this is the make-or-break metric.

• Free → Paid conversion > 8% — industry average for Indian EdTech freemium is 3–5%.

• WhatsApp group virality — assumes warm referrals work at scale; may plateau at ~50 colleges.

• Rs 99 starter tier actually converts — Rs 99 feels cheap but students will still churn if value isn't felt in Day 1–7.

■■ 03 Business Model Canvas

Key Partners

• OpenAI / Anthropic (AI APIs) • College tech clubs & TPOs • YouTube / Instagram creators • Razorpay (payments) • Antler India / Surge (capital)

Key Activities

• AI roadmap generation • Skill-gap assessment engine • Content curation & verification • Retention loop design • College community growth

Value Propositions

• Personalised AI career roadmap in 60 sec • Skill-gap diagnosis before interviews • Affordable (Rs 99–499) vs Rs 5K+ human coaching • Progress accountability layer • India-native pricing & context

Customer Relationships

• Self-serve freemium onboarding • Daily WhatsApp / email nudges • Streak-based habit loops • Peer referral community • Weekly progress reports

Customer Segments

• Primary: Tier 2/3 B.Tech Yr 3–4 (placement-anxious) • Secondary: Yr 2 early planners • Future: Entry-level employees (0–2 yrs exp) • B2B: College placement cells (pivot option)

Key Resources

• AI model integrations • Curated roadmap templates • Founder's technical skills • Early user community • Prototype / codebase

Channels

• Instagram Reels (awareness) • College WhatsApp groups (conversion) • Friend referral programme • YouTube creator partnerships • Organic SEO (medium term)

Cost Structure

• AI API costs (OpenAI/Anthropic tokens) • Cloud hosting (Vercel / AWS) • Content creation (video / copy) • Founder salary (deferred) • Legal & compliance (DPDP Act)

Revenue Streams

• Monthly SaaS: Rs 99 / 299 / 499 • Annual plan: Rs 1,999/yr • Future: B2B college licences Rs 5L–50L/yr • Future: Corporate L&D; white-label • Future: Placement referral fees

■ 04 Revenue & Pricing Strategy

Pricing Ladder

rice	Features	Target User	Conversion Goal
s 0	7-day full access → 1 roadmap, limited tracking	Discovery cohort	Sign up; complete onboarding
s 99/mo	Full roadmap + progress tracker + daily nudges	Yr 2–3, price-sensitive	> 8% of free users
s 299/mo	Starter + skill-gap refresh + company prep tips	Yr 4, placement season	Upsell from Starter in Month 2
s 1,999/yr	Pro features at Rs 166/mo effective (~44% saving)	Committed learners	Push from Month 3; reduces churn
s 499/mo	Pro + mock interview prep + priority content drops	High-intent, higher income	Top 5% of Pro users

Revenue Model & Unit Economics

etric	Assumption	Source / Rationale
ended ARPU	Rs 200/month (~$2.4/yr)	Weighted avg across Starter/Pro mix
ee → Paid conv.	Target: 8% (realistic: 4–6%)	India EdTech freemium avg: 3–5%
30 Retention	Target: 25% (unvalidated)	Benchmark: 20–30% for habit apps
V (12-mo)	Rs 2,400 (~$29)	12 × Rs 200 blended ARPU
AC Target	< Rs 300 (<$3.60)	LTV:CAC > 8:1 needed for SaaS health
yback Period	1.5 months (if CAC < Rs 300)	Positive at Starter tier
ar 1 Target	Rs 1–2 Cr ($120K–$240K)	2,000–4,000 paying users × Rs 500/mo avg

Revenue Risk Flags

- India freemium conversion reality: 3–5%, not 8%. Budget for the conservative case in your model.
- Seasonal revenue concentration: 70%+ of new paying users likely in Oct–Nov and Feb–Mar placement seasons.
- AI API costs (OpenAI/Anthropic) scale with usage — model abstraction to open-source LLMs needed by Month 6.
- Annual plan cannibalises monthly revenue short-term but is essential for LTV — push it hard from Month 3.
- B2B college channel (Rs 5L–50L/year contracts) could 10x revenue per deal but adds 3–6 month sales cycles.

■ 05 Go-To-Market Strategy

GTM Phases

Horizon	Channel	Tactic	KPI
Month 1–2	WhatsApp Groups + Referral	Manually seed 5–10 target college WhatsApp groups. Offer founder's personal number for feedback. 1-month-free referral.	300 signups 30 paying users
Month 3–4	Instagram Reels + YouTube Shorts	5 short-form videos/week: '3 DSA mistakes killing your placement'. Collaborate with 2 micro-influencers (50K–200K followers).	5,000 signups 400 paying users
Month 5–6	Paid Retargeting + College Clubs	Meta/Google retarget visitors who did not convert. Partner with 20 college tech clubs for free trials + ambassador program.	D30 > 25% CAC < Rs 300
Month [illegible]–12	Direct Sales to TPOs	Target Training & Placement Officers at 50 Tier 2/3 colleges. Pilot: Rs 50K/semester per college (100 students). Annual deal target: Rs 5L+.	5 college pilots Rs 25L ARR

Positioning Statement

For engineering students at Tier 2/3 colleges in India who feel lost before placement season, **SkillBoost AI** is the AI career co-pilot that **delivers a personalised learning roadmap and tracks your progress** — unlike generic YouTube tutorials or overworked placement cells, **SkillBoost AI tells you exactly what to learn, in what order, and holds you accountable**.

Investor One-Liner

"SkillBoost AI is the AI-powered career co-pilot for India's 5 million underserved Tier 2/3 engineering students — replacing Rs 50,000/month human coaches with a Rs 99/month subscription that delivers personalised roadmaps, skill-gap diagnosis, and placement accountability."

30-Second Founder Pitch

"India graduates 1.5 million engineers every year. Over 80% don't land jobs relevant to their degree — not because they're not smart, but because they have no idea what to learn, in what order, or how to track progress. I was that student. Career coaches cost Rs 50,000 a month. YouTube is a rabbit hole. I built SkillBoost AI — an AI that gives any student a personalised career roadmap, identifies their skill gaps, and nudges them daily — for Rs 99 a month. We're pre-revenue, 30-day retention is our next gate, and we're targeting 30 paying users this month. The window is now — before Unacademy figures out personalisation."

■ 06 Customer Acquisition & First 100 Users Plan

First 100 Paying Users — Step by Step

tion	Target	Tool / Channel
rsonal network — DM 50 students from your college ch and WhatsApp contacts	Users 1–20	WhatsApp, LinkedIn DM
ed 3 college WhatsApp groups with a free trial offer + sonal founder note	Users 21–80	WhatsApp groups
st 3 Instagram Reels: 'I built an AI that gives you a free cement roadmap'	Users 81–150	Instagram, YouTube Shorts
unch referral: existing users get 1 month free for every d friend they bring	Users 151–250	In-app referral flow
rtner with 1 college tech club: offer free access to all mbers for 2 weeks	Users 251–400	Email / club WhatsApp
ft-launch Rs 99/month to your 50 most active free users wer users)	Paying 1–30	In-app paywall + Razorpay
ate on onboarding: interview 5 churned users to identify y 1–3 drop-off causes	Paying 31–100	Calendly + Loom recording

Customer Acquisition Strategy by Channel

	Est. CAC	Scale Potential	Priority	Key Risk
p Groups	Rs 0–50	Medium (plateau ~50 colleges)	■ #1 NOW	Needs manual seeding; doesn't scale without ambassadors
Programme	Rs 99 credit	High (viral if product works)	■ #2 NOW	Only works if D30 retention > 25% first
Reels (organic)	Rs 100–300	Very High	■ Month 2	Algorithm-dependent; requires consistent content output
Shorts / Collab	Rs 200–500	High	■ Month 2	Creator relationships take time; ROI is slow
ogle Paid Ads	Rs 500–1,500	Very High (with budget)	■ Month 4+	LTV:CAC only works if D30 > 25%; don't burn before then
lub Partnerships	Rs 0–200	Medium	■ Month 3	Requires on-ground relationship building; slow per college
B Direct Sales	Rs 0 (founder time)	High per deal value	■ Month 7+	Long sales cycle; legal procurement hurdles

■ 07 Competitive Position & Moat

	AI Personalisation	Career Path Mapping	India Pricing	Tier 2/3 Focus	Threat Level
	■ Core feature	■ Core feature	■ Rs 99–499	■ Primary ICP	—
	■ No AI	■■ Partial	■ Free–Rs 399	■ Strong reach	■ HIGH
	■■ Basic	■ No	■ Affordable	■■ Some reach	■ MED
	■ No	■ Exam-centric	■ India-native	■■ Partial	■ MED
ing	■■ Basic	■ No	■ Too expensive	■ Metro-only	■ LOW
ude	■ High	■■ Manual	■ USD pricing	■■ No structure	■ HIGH
es	■ Yes (human)	■ Yes	■ Rs 5K–50K/mo	■ Metro-only	■ LOW

Moat Analysis

Moat Type	Assessment
Data Moat (Medium-term)	Every roadmap generated + user progress data trains better recommendations. First-mover advantage in Tier 2/3 data is defensible once 10K+ users are active.
Community Moat (Build now)	WhatsApp groups, college ambassador networks, and placement success stories create word-of-mouth that competitors cannot buy.
Brand Moat (6–12 months)	'SkillBoost AI got me placed at TCS' — one viral success story in a college WhatsApp group is worth Rs 10L in ads. Systematise this.
Distribution Moat (Critical gap)	Currently NO moat. Internshala and GUVI already have Tier 2/3 distribution. This must be solved before Series A.
AI Personalisation (12-month window)	No competitor has shipped AI roadmap personalisation at India pricing. The window is 12–18 months before GUVI or Internshala copies it.

■■ 08 Reverse SWOT Analysis

Reverse SWOT flips conventional thinking: How can Weaknesses become entry barriers? How can Threats become advantages?

Strengths → Double Down

Factor	Reverse Action
Lived founder-problem fit	Use personal story in every marketing asset. Authenticity is the cheapest CAC.
Technical founder	Ship weekly. Speed of iteration is a moat against funded competitors with process overhead.
AI-native architecture	Build the personalisation loop competitors will take 12 months to replicate.

Weaknesses → Convert or Neutralise

Factor	Reverse Action
Solo founder	Join Antler India in next cohort — instant co-founder matching + Rs 1Cr pre-seed + network.
No distribution moat	Partner with 1 large Tier 2/3 college by Month 3. One college = 2,000+ students = proof of B2B channel.
Unproven retention	Run a 30-person 'placement cohort' experiment: hold weekly group accountability calls. Manual but proves the loop.

Opportunities → Capture Fast

Factor	Reverse Action
Placement season urgency	Launch a 'Placement Season Sprint' campaign every Oct and Feb. Time-boxed urgency drives conversion.
NEP 2020 tailwind	Apply for NASSCOM / Startup India grants tied to skill development — non-dilutive capital.
B2B college pivot	One Rs 5L/semester college deal funds 6 months of runway without dilution.

Threats → Reframe as Advantages

Factor	Reverse Action
ChatGPT as competitor	Use this to educate: 'ChatGPT gives generic advice; SkillBoost AI knows your college, your batch, your gaps.'
Unacademy / GUVI copy risk	Move fast; their organisational inertia means 12–18 months. Build community moat they can't copy.
Price sensitivity	Reframe: 'Rs 99/month vs Rs 50,000/month human coach' — frame up, not down.

■ 09 Investment Scorecard

#	Dimension	Score	Reasoning
1	**Business Viability**	**71/100**	Problem is real and large. Revenue model is logical. Key unknown: will D30 retention validate the habit loop? Score improves to 80+ once 200-user cohort proves 25%+ D30.
2	**Revenue Potential**	**78/100**	SAM of $4.2B is credible. ARPU of Rs 200 is conservative. B2B pivot could 10x deal size. Risk: India student CAC may exceed LTV if retention fails.
3	**GTM Strength**	**66/100**	WhatsApp + Reels strategy is right for the market. Weakness: no owned distribution channel yet. Internshala has 20M+ users and Tier 2/3 reach. GTM score jumps when 1 college partnership is signed.
4	**Competitive Strength**	**63/100**	Unique positioning today, but no durable moat. ChatGPT and Internshala are credible threats. 12-month window to build community + data moat before feature-copying begins.
5	**Investor Readiness**	**59/100**	Strong founder-market fit story. Weak: no traction metrics, no co-founder, no retention proof. Pre-seed investors (Antler, Surge) will fund the story; seed investors need D30 > 25% + 50 paying users.

71	78	66	63	59
Biz Viability	Rev. Potential	GTM Strength	Comp. Strength	Investor Ready

OVERALL INVESTMENT SCORE: 67/100 | ■ VALIDATE — Strong story, needs traction proof

What moves this to ■ Investable?

- D30 retention > 25% in a 200-user cohort → adds +10 to Investor Readiness
- 50 paying users at Rs 99+ → proves WTP and free→paid conversion → adds +8 to Revenue Potential
- 1 signed college partnership (TPO deal) → proves B2B channel → adds +7 to GTM Strength
- Co-founder with growth / sales background → reduces solo-founder risk → adds +6 to Business Viability
- Accelerator acceptance (Antler / Surge) → credibility signal → adds +5 to Investor Readiness

■ 10 Founder Action Sheet — Top 10 Non-Negotiable Actions

y	Action	When	Success Signal	Why It Matters
TICAL	Prove D30 retention > 25% with 100+ users	Day 1	PostHog / Mixpanel cohort retention chart	Without this, no investor will write a cheque. Everything else is secondary.
TICAL	Get 30 paying users at Rs 99/month	Week 4	Razorpay dashboard showing 30 active subscriptions	Revenue > users. 30 paying students is more powerful than 3,000 signups.
GENT	Recruit a co-founder (growth / GTM profile)	Week 2–4	3+ serious conversations initiated	AngelList, IIT/NIT alumni groups, Antler India cohort matching.
GENT	Apply to Antler India / Surge / YC	Week 4	Application submitted	Antler India invests pre-traction. YC batches close Jan & June. Apply now.
H	Rebuild onboarding: first roadmap in < 60 seconds	Days 6–10	Onboarding completion rate > 65%	If users don't see value in 3 minutes, they leave. Speed of value = retention.
H	Sign 1 college partnership (tech club or TPO)	Week 3	MOU or WhatsApp confirmation from 1 TPO	One college = 2,000+ students + social proof + B2B revenue signal.
D	Launch referral programme: 1-month free per paying friend	Week 3	Viral coefficient > 0.4 (track referral source in PostHog)	Referral only works after retention is proven — don't activate before D30 data.
D	Post 5 Instagram Reels and measure CTR	Week 3	CTR > 3% on at least 1 video	Hook: 'I built an AI that gives you a free DSA roadmap in 60 seconds'. Show the pr
D	Register as Private Limited Company via Razorpay Rize	Week 2	CIN number received	Needed for Razorpay payments, accelerator applications, and investor due diligen
N	Build model abstraction layer (OpenAI → open-source LLM fallback)	Month 2	Cost per roadmap < Rs 2	AI API costs will kill margins at scale. Abstract the model layer now while user cou

■ 11 Sustainability Verdict

SkillBoost AI is targeting a genuinely painful, massive, and chronically underserved problem — and the founder's lived experience gives it an authentic edge that no funded competitor can manufacture. The business can become sustainable, but only if two gates are cleared in the next 30 days: D30 retention above 25% (proving the habit loop works) and 30 paying users at Rs 99+ (proving willingness to pay). Without these two data points, the product is a compelling hypothesis, not a business. The structural opportunity is real: no single player combines AI personalisation, career path mapping, and India-native pricing — and the 12–18 month window before larger EdTech players pivot to this segment is narrow but real. Distribution, not product, is the critical risk: the founder must build an owned acquisition channel (college partnerships, referral flywheel, or content engine) before attempting to raise. A co-founder with GTM skills would double the probability of success. Verdict: SkillBoost AI is a ■ Validate-stage business with ■ Investable potential — the next 30 days of execution will determine which it becomes.